

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE PROMISED HOUSE

The campaign for the 2019 general election was in full spate when Smriti Irani, the BJP candidate from Amethi, had promised building a house there if she won. That came to pass, the Union minister bought a 15,000 sq. ft plot of land in Amethi's Gauriganj tehsil in 2021 and, on February 22 this year, held a housewarming ceremony (just days after Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra crossed the constituency). With speculation now that Rahul will again contest from here, we'll have to wait and see how auspicious the new house is for Irani. Its boundary walls make no secret of her party's campaign focus, adorned as they are with scenes from the Ramayana.



Ramayana in Bihar

While remarking on **Nitish Kumar's** February 12 trust vote, Opposition leader Tejashwi Yadav described the Bihar CM as King Dashrath who had exiled his son Ram. He also spoke of a 'Kaikeyi', who had poisoned the CM's ears and got him to break the alliance with the RJD-Congress. On February 25, Tejashwi added a new twist to the Bihar Ramayana, telling reporters in Patna that there were 3-4 Kaikeyis and a Manthara too. "The CM should get rid of them, or in time we'll expose them ourselves," he said. Enough to pique everyone's curiosity, for sure.

Power Goals



Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan can go to any lengths for bureaucrats close to him. His latest act of benevolence is elevating chief principal secretary **K.M. Abraham** to cabinet rank. The 65-year-old bureaucrat, who retired as chief secretary, has rejoined the CM's office, and also holds additional charge as CEO of the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB). The 1982 batch IAS officer, considered the most powerful babu in the state, is a former SEBI member who investigated the Sahara scam. It's the first time a bureaucrat has been given cabinet rank in Kerala. While politicians envy Abraham his cabinet status, babus in the state have found a new career goal.

A STATE OF SPEAKERS







There is something about Speakers from Rajasthan. Speaker of the current assembly, **Vasudev Devnani,** is aggressive but managed his first session well. Lok Sabha speaker **Om Birla** has received kudos from PM Narendra Modi and is a major player in state politics, though he is a tad worried now as the BJP lost four assembly seats in his constituency, Bundi-Kota. He's also in the race for the CM's post if ever the leadership feels a change is in order. As for Birla's counterpart in the Upper House, vice-president **Jagdeep Dhankhar**, all official visits to his home state set tongues wagging.

Blessing in Disguise?



A few in the Congress camp feel the tie-up with AAP in Gujarat cost them two big Lok Sabha seats—Bharuch, the late Ahmed Patel's base, where his children Faisal and Mumtaz were both laying claim, and Bhavnagar, hometown of state chief **Shaktisinh Gohil.** But the truth is the BJP has won the Bharuch seat the past seven times and the AAP candidate there, Chaitar Vasava, is a formidable opponent. In Bhavnagar, Umesh Makwana, a first-time MLA, is in the ring. Gohil, whose party is down to 17 seats in the assembly, has a lot on his hands anyway with the other 24 LS seats.

Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Amitabh Srivastava, Jeemon Jacob, Rohit Parihar and Jumana Shah